prompted through a series of questions to make grave allegations relating to an alleged incident in or around the year 2011", noted the injunction order.

A whirlpool of accusations ensued. Leading the Opposition charge was H.D. Kumaraswamy, Union minister for Steel and Heavy Industries. He went straight for DKS, with whom he has a running feud for Vokkaliga dominance. Calling him a sting "samrat", HDK claimed the sting had originally been part of a tactic to force Sidda out of power. Rising to the latter's defence, he said Sidda had himself named a recently expelled Congress functionary, Kripa Alva, and Kannada TV channel owner Rakesh Shetty as orchestrating the video for blackmail. Investigations were intentionally slow, he added.

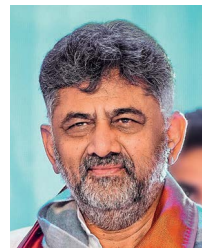
Soon came another twist. The Bengaluru police—which said preliminary evidence pointed to a "fabricated narrative" and "unsubstantiated allegations" about a purported sexual abuse incident—found the phone used for uploading the video had been bought at a shop in Delhi's Karol Bagh. On October 24, it arrested a social media creator, Ritesh Pandey, from the National Capital Region in this connection.

With a twofold objective: damaging Sidda's credibility while blaming DKS. A furious Kumaraswamy accused the cops of acting at the behest of their political masters and not going after those who had made the recording in the first place. "Hundreds of people visit my residence in Delhi. The gates are always open," he said, refuting the insinuations and daring the police to take action against him.

That linked up with an old grudge against DKS, dating back to the 2024 Hassan rape cases that had gotten his nephew Prajwal Revanna convicted and jailed. The ex-MP is also undergoing trial in other sexual assault cases arising from the leak of explicit videos.

Before the media, HDK flashed call detail records to claim that a former driver of Revanna, accused of leaking the sex videos, had been to DKS's residence in 2023, months before the leaks. "I'm very clear. My fight is not to indulge in character assassination but against those running CD factories and sting operations to blackmail people," he said.

Barring any video surprises, what happens next may hinge on the probe that's under way. But the presence of one CM and two ex-CMs, one of them a Union minister, shows how high the stakes are. The runup to the 2028 assembly poll has begun in earnest. ■





Takeaways

- **Days after DKS *(left)* warns of stings, an old video targeting Sidda hits social media. He gets injunction**
- **Kumaraswamy *(right)* alleges DKS's hand in the 'sting'. The CM's counter: trail goes to HDK in Delhi**
- **The two are competitors for the Vokkaliga vote; HDK still smarting over Revanna case**

THE TRAIL GOES MANY WAYS

On November 1, Bengaluru police commissioner Seemant Kumar Singh made an explosive revelation: that Pandey had claimed to be working on the instructions of one Prajwal Prasad, to whom he handed over the phone at HDK's official Delhi residence. The claim was being verified, Singh said.

It was now the Congress's turn to go on the offensive. It accused HDK of 'masterminding' the video's release.

BIMAL SAHA TYPIFIES ONE KIND OF public servant, a sort that had allegedly proliferated in Bengal. A sub-assistant engineer at the Jamboni block in Jhargram district, here he was, asking for Rs 93,000 more after Rs 1 lakh. Contractor Biswajit Mallick stepped out, took a car kept ready for him by a few waiting men, went to friends who had promised to keep cash handy, returned and handed it over to Saha. The men then came in. Sleuths of the Anti-Corruption Branch (ACB) of West Bengal, they caught the errant official—well, *purple*-handed.

Saha had been needling Mallick for cash to sanction an invoice. "I'd had no respite for a few years," says the contractor. Tired of the ordeal, he lodged a complaint with the ACB. The agency wields two weapons: the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988, and phenolphthalein powder. The Act determines the ACB's remit; the chemical helps nail the crime. The invisible powder is dusted on currency notes. Once the accused handles

